11 The Need for Excellence

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Discussion

1. Do you think that excellence is required even in business, even though the goal of business is to make money? Why?
2. Can you name some of the respected business leaders of contemporary India?
3. What do you understand by human resources?
4. Why is it important to have skilful management of human resources in any company?
5. What is the role design plays in the world of business?

About the Author

N. R. Narayana Murthy (1946–) is one of India's best-known entrepreneurs and of Infosys Technologies Limited, a global tech.nology services company. In 1981, along with six friends, he formed Infosys. When the liberalisation of the Indian economy began in 1991, Murthy grabbed the opportunity with both hands and Infosys became the first Indian company to be listed on the US NASDAQ.

Narayana Murthy has been voted as one of the most admired and respected business leaders in the world as well as one of the most influential Asians in modern history in numerous international polls. Murthy is known for his simplicity and humility. This piece is a convocation address delivered to students of the National Institute of Design (Ahmedabad), and features in his book *A Better India, A Better World*.

Reading

In many ways, graduation day signifies that you have joined the ranks of adults. You are now entitled to a lifetime of paying taxes and innumerable kinds of bills! The good news is that the opportunities before you are also endless. Your illustrious institution has equipped you to realise your dreams—the future is now yours to choose.

During your stay here, you may have visited the Sabarmati Ashram nearby, and been inspired by that place. I want to ask you a fundamental question that was evident in many of Mahatma Gandhi's speeches. Why is it that India does not boast of any product of international class and international recognition? We do have many successes including a vibrant democracy, a free press and an independent judiciary. We have the third largest pool of world-class scientists

and engineers, and have gained self-sufficiency in foodgrains as well as in building dams, rockets and satellites. However, there is no single field where we can confidently say, 'We are the best in the world.'

You should ponder over this question since design plays a crucial role in the success of any product, be it ceramics, manufactured goods or software applications. In fact, I believe that the long-term success of a technology is dependent on how quickly it becomes user-friendly. Let me take the example of Information Technology (IT). In the past, we were more concerned with optimal use of hardware rather than with user-friendliness and ease of software development. Today's computers have 66,000 times the computing power, at the same cost, of the computers built in 1975. Thus, improvements in computing power over the years have led to increasing the emphasis on effectiveness and ease of use for the customer. This industry has realised that delivering effective solutions requires addressing the human aspects of the solutions. In fact, Graphical User Interfaces (GUIs) have become the industry norm. The ongoing convergence of IT and consumer electronics portends the emergence of even more user-friendly and intelligent goods. Therefore, design will continue to play an important role in this technology-driven world.

Let me briefly talk about the reasons behind India's poor performance in creating world-class products and services and what we can do about it.

A crucial factor for success has always been excellence—whether it is business, sports or arts. We have not paid enough attention to excellence. Perhaps an important reason for this was the command-and-control economy that existed till recently. In those times, there was no incentive for improvement as the Licence Raj ensured protection for incumbents.

Political considerations forced successive governments to cling on to misguided notions of socialism. Luxury was looked down upon. It was politically more correct to provide basic accommodation rather than to construct an impressive building. This, by itself, could be excused as part of the travails of development with its emphasis on quantity rather than quality. However, what was disturbing was the creation of a mindset that equated high quality with exorbitant costs. Thus, the government felt reasonably justified in delivering substandard goods and services to its citizens. This sapped our confidence in our ability to provide world-class goods and services to our people.

Success in independent India was then due to whom you knew rather than what you could do. The pervasive bureaucracy led to widespread suspicions of any nongovernmental initiative. The use of the 'tender' process for awarding contracts purely based on cost rather than credentials became widespread.

Another misguided notion was the belief that consumer goods are, at best, a necessary evil. The Mahalanobis model emphasised capital goods vis-a-vis consumer goods. The socialist system introduced many other vices into the country. Perhaps the most important of these was the lack of accountability. People who ran governments and public sector institutions were accountable to no one but themselves.

Fortunately, the old mindset is changing for the better. The liberalisation of the Indian economy in the early 1990s has brought in a new context and forced this change. Indian companies have started dreaming of competing with the best in the world. In fact, it was liberalisation that laid the foundation for the success of the Indian software industry.

The forces of globalisation and technology are reshaping our world. Global trade now accounts for nearly 25 per cent of the world's GDP. Privatisation has become a global phenomenon with more than a hundred countries pursuing the privatisation agenda. The internet has grown to reach more than 450 million users. The mapping of the human genome will possibly lead to the development of new categories of drugs and improve the quality of our lives. These are

fundamental forces at work. In fact, the world you are stepping into is vastly different from the one that we lived in even ten years ago.

In these times, you will be competing with the best in the world. The task before you is no doubt arduous. Years of protectionism have sapped Indian companies of their creativity and emphasis on excellence. However, you must strive hard to mould the view among decision-makers that India is synonymous with not just competitive costs but also high quality. Indian companies are increasingly establishing their presence in global markets. They are your natural allies. As they build the brand of India Inc., you must be there to assist them in doing so.

Pursue excellence. Aim high and dream big. Make excellence in execution your core belief. Remember, excellence can be acquired only by relentless training, frank feedback and constant self-improvement. Such excellence can prosper only in an environment where it is recognised and rewarded. Strive to create such an environment at your workplace.

Your dreams and your enthusiasm are of utmost importance. As you step into the real world, remain young at heart and be open to new ideas. Never accept the status quo. Endeavour to be the best in the world in whatever you choose to be. Remember the words of Harold Taylor: 'The roots of true achievement lie in the will to become the best that you can become.'

Finally, remember that words mean nothing unless backed by actions. Henry Ford often said, 'You cannot build a reputation on what you are going to do.' Therefore, build your reputation with your achievement. The nation needs you.

GLOSSARY

illustrious /ɪˈlʌstrɪəs/ : distinguished, famous

fundamental /fʌndəˈmentəl/ : basic; going to the root of something

vibrant democracy /ˈvaɪbrənt dɪˈmɒkrəsɪ/ : a government of the people that is full of vitality or energy

judiciary /dʒuːˈdɪʃərɪ/ : a body of judges or people who have judicial power, that is, the power to judge and pass orders on any dispute

self-sufficiency /ˈselfsəˈfɪʃənsɪ/ : a condition of being able to supply one's needs oneself, self-reliant

satellite /ˈsætəlaɪt/ : an artificial object placed in an orbit round the earth or a celestial object

crucial /ˈkruːʃəl/ : decisive; that which decides between hypotheses

ceramics /səˈræmɪks/ : the art of pottery; designing or pertaining to hard brittle substances produced by strong heating

software applications /ˈsɒftweər æplɪˈkeɪʃənz/ : the use of the programmes and other operating information in actual computer practice

computing power /kəmˈpjuːtɪŋˈpaʊə/ : the ability to determine something by calculation and computation

convergence /kənˈvɜːdʒəns/ : the action or property of coming together

consumer electronics /kənˈsjumərɪlekˈtrɒnɪks/ : the use of electronic goods from the point of view of the smaller consumer

portend /pɔːˈtend/ : foretell something in an ominous or warning manner

exorbitant /ɪgˈzɔːbɪtənt/ : lavish, excessive in terms of price

bureaucracy /bjʊəˈrɒkrəsɪ/ : a group of government officials who are appointed rather than elected

vis-á-vis /ˈvɪːzɑːˈviː/ : regarding or relating to

genome /ˈdʒɪːnəʊm/ : the complete set of genes or genetic material present in a cell

privatisation /ˈpraɪvətaɪˈzeɪʃən/ : the process of assigning enterprise to private bodies, as opposed to public or State bodies

protectionism /prəˈtekʃənɪzəm/ : the theory of protecting domestic industries from the competition of foreign goods

status quo /ˈsteɪtəsˈkwəʊ/ : the state of things as they are; the existing order

EXERCISES

1. *Answer the following questions in about 50 to 100 words each.*

   a. Why does Narayana Murthy state that India is deficient in the quality of excellence?
   b. Who does the author quote as having said this? M·K·Gandhi
   c. How has the development of computing power helped the customer?
   d. What has been the chief reason for a lack of attention to excellence in India, according to Narayana Murthy?
   e. Why has the Indian government been satisfied with compromise on quality in the past?
   f. What was the evil introduced by the socialist system in India?
   g. How has liberalisation of the Indian economy brought in a change in ways of thinking?
   h. How should young graduates change the general perception with regard to Indian companies?

2. *Answer the following questions in about 150 to 200 words each.*

   a. Bring out Narayana Murthy's exhortation to the young graduates to pursue excellence.
   b. What is the contrast between the India of the past and India of the present in terms of business enterprise and economical structures?
   c. Discuss the new equations that have been brought into the mindset of young entrepreneurs in the light of liberalisation and new technologies.

WRITING

Informal letters

Informal, or personal letters, are written to friends and relatives. Their tone is therefore informal and the style used informal or, sometimes, even conversational. Informal letters could be about your home, family, work or something interesting that happened to you. Thus, a letter written to a classmate describing the farewell party that she could not attend and a letter written to your brother enquiring about his health are examples of informal letters.

An informal letter has six parts. They are as follows.

- **The sender's address:** If there has been a recent change in your address or if you are writing to a person for the first time, your complete address must be given. If you do not live in the same country as the person you are writing to, write the name of your country. In the modern style of letter writing, the address is not punctuated. Note that the address of the person you are writing to (the 'inside address') need not be given in an informal letter.
- **The date:** According to current practice, there is no comma between the year and the rest of the date, as in '6 March 2013'. In the modern block style of letter writing, the sender's address and date are placed on the top left-hand margin.
- **The salutation:** The salutation is always written at the left-hand margin of the page. It is followed by a comma. The salutation is usually in the form of 'Dear . . .' The salutation 'My dear . . .' suggests intimacy and is used only when writing to relatives or close friends, as